

GOP polling collapse puts larger Democratic Senate majority in play

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State government control in 2026 will shape the 2028 landscape through redistricting

GOP polling collapse puts larger Democratic Senate majority in play. This was probably Democrats' strongest week of polling since the 2018 midterms, making Republican hopes of retaining the House even fainter and putting a serious squeeze on Republican candidates in key Senate races.

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After months of stasis, the generic congressional ballot moved decisively in Democrats' direction this week. They now hold a 7.8-point advantage in Silver Bulletin's all-voters average – a full point improved on last week – and buoyed by a series of extremely strong polls from high-quality pollsters like Marquette University, Quinnipiac University, and the New York Times.
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Though Republican spending—which we thought would tilt races back toward Republicans—has begun to materialize in key races, that effect appears to be substantially outweighed by macroeconomic factors, especially gas and diesel prices.
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The good vibes for the overall party are showing up down-ballot.

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Texas is, at this point, flashing bright-red warning lights for Republicans. Ken Paxton has led Democrat James Talarico in only one poll since the end of June. An Emerson poll yesterday showed Talarico up by one, a result that looks even worse once you know that Emerson's sample leaned a whopping twelve points Republican by party ID. If Paxton can't lead in that sample, it suggests his longstanding flaws as a candidate are seriously dragging down his campaign, and Talarico should be seen as the favorite.
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In Alaska, the first high-quality poll since mid-August showed Democrat Mary Peltola up by six points against Senator Dan Sullivan (R-AK)—and, crucially, just surpassing the 50% barrier in the first round of the state’s ranked-choice election. Sullivan led by three in a co/efficient poll yesterday, but that should be read as essentially a tie, given the firm’s historical slight lean toward Republicans. It is becoming increasingly difficult to argue that Sullivan should be favored here.

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Perhaps most worryingly for Republicans, Democrats do look now to be meaningfully expanding the map into states where the GOP should be heavy favorites. The Nebraska race is tied; Senator Roger Marshall (R-KS) trailed in a recent poll in Kansas, and even Florida features a Republican lead of under five points. None of these races are likely to go toward Democrats, but the very prospect of competitive races there will force Republicans to play defense, diverting funds from elsewhere.

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In combination, these developments indicate that a larger Democratic Senate majority—beyond 51 seats—is in reach in our 45% scenario that Democrats win the Senate (see Republicans retain razor-thin lead in Senate race , 8 September 2026). On current polling, Democrats would have 52 seats, or 53 if Iowa goes their way too. In the 2024 cycle, all presidential swing states broke toward Republicans; that same phenomenon is a rising possibility this year.

Democrats' polling will probably improve in three vulnerable states. The positive topline polling and expanding Senate battlefield aside, Democrats look weaker than they should in three states where they currently hold the seat: Michigan, Minnesota, and New Hampshire.

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Republicans aren’t outright favorites in any of these races, but the polling in each is tighter than the generic ballot would suggest. In fact, they’re even tighter than are most of the Republican-held tossups; based on current polling averages, Minnesota would be Democrats’ 52nd seat, with Maine the tipping point.

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These races will probably shift toward Democrats in the waning days of the campaign. In Minnesota, every poll has shown a much higher-than-usual percentage of undecided voters, who will probably break towards Democrats (the Democratic gubernatorial candidate holds a 16-point lead). In Michigan, we’re more likely to see Democrat Abdul El-Sayed’s support creep back up toward the partisan baseline of the state—likely around D+7 this year—than to revert back to a tie.

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If Republicans win any of these races, that would substantially shore up the Republican Senate majority: Democrats would need another pickup of a Republican-held seat to offset it. Expect Republicans to keep up their advertising blitz in New Hampshire, with its small media market, as a result, forcing Democrats onto the defensive.

State government control in 2026 will shape the 2028 landscape through redistricting. Democrats’ chances of retaining a potential House majority at the 2028 election depend in large part on their ability to undo Republicans’ redistricting gains in this cycle, which will require Democrats taking power and redistricting states to their own advantage.

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Watch a small number of states where Democrats are seeking redistricting power: Oregon, Pennsylvania, and Georgia. In Oregon and Pennsylvania, Democrats are seeking trifectas; in Georgia, they are seeking to win the governor's race, blocking unified Republican control of state government.

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Democrats are facing headwinds in all of these races despite their success at the national level. In Oregon, the Democratic gubernatorial candidate is polling neck and neck with the Republican candidate; in Pennsylvania, the tipping-point races in the state Senate are leaning just barely toward Republicans; in Georgia, former Atlanta mayor Keisha Lance Bottoms is running just behind her Republican competitor.

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If Democrats don't win these races, expect the 2028 redistricting picture to look only slightly better for them than the 2026 one does—which will, all else equal, reduce their likelihood of retaining the House.

Quote of the Day

"Do I want to go in and annihilate them or do I not? It's a big decision. Anything could happen with me." - President Donald Trump speaking to Axios about the war with Iran. While a continued standoff remains Eurasia Group's base case (60% odds), a deal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz remains unlikely this year (15% odds), and escalation is a continued risk (25% odds, please see: Standoff now likely to run through 2026 as Hormuz traffic increases , 31 August 2026).

On the Radar

18-28 September: High-Level Week at UN General Assembly

24 September: Trump-Xi summit

2 October: Last day Senate is in session before midterms

3 November: National midterm elections

10 November: US-China tariff truce expires

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

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